

Figure 5.13 *Bust, arch, front face and intrados, north, carved geometric decoration and inscription, detail. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

On stylistic analysis particularly of the arch's epigraphy and geometric decoration, Sourdel-Thomine dated it to the third quarter of the twelfth century, basing the date range on comparisons with the epigraphy of Shah-i Mashhad.[37] As we saw in Chapter 4, the period of construction for that *madrasa* complex likely spanned a decade, from AH 561 to 571 (1165–1176 CE). Thus, a date for the arch at the end of this range (*c*. AH 570/1175 CE) would not be implausible.

Several aspects of the Bust arch suggest that it served as a triumphal monument commemorating an event falling within Shansabani ascendancy in the region. In his re-surveying of the Bust citadel, T. Allen proposed that the arch was part of a reconfiguration of the principal, ceremonial entrance into the lower enclave, which in itself served as a gateway to the upper more insulated area.[38] The arch was thus a public – even "civic" – structure, and also evinced an association with royalty and its ceremonial expression. With the proposed date of *c*. AH 570/1175 CE for the arch as a basis, it is conceivable that this monument was erected in virtual